

## **LEARNING TO SELF-SOOTHE**

### **GOALS OF THE EXERCISE**

1. Maintain a program of recovery from addiction and reduce the negative effects of Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) on learning, social interaction, and self-esteem.
2. Develop the skills necessary to cope with ADHD symptoms and addiction.
3. Develop the skills necessary to bring ADHD symptoms under control so that normal learning can take place.

### **ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PROBLEMS WITH ATTENTION-DEFICIT/HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER**

- A Different Approach
- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- From Recklessness to Calculated Risks
- Getting Organized
- Interest and Skill Self-Assessment
- Working toward Independence

### **ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL**

- Anxiety
- Borderline Traits
- Chronic Pain
- Eating Disorders
- Grief/Loss Unresolved
- Medical Issues
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Social Anxiety/Skills Deficit
- Substance-Induced Disorders
- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal
- Suicidal Ideation

## **SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT**

The “Learning to Self-Soothe” activity is useful for clients who will benefit from learning to recognize the signs that their agitation is escalating, and from gaining a skill to help them calm down. Repetition is the key to mastery of this skill, and this exercise can be used as a check-in and review at the initiation and/or conclusion of every individual or group therapy session.

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## LEARNING TO SELF-SOOTHE

For people coping with attentional difficulties and/or impulsive decision-making issues, learning to calm themselves can improve learning, relationships, and self-esteem, and can help avoid negative outcomes in many situations. It can replace self-destructive coping mechanisms, such as using addictive behavior patterns to reduce restlessness, boredom, irritability, low frustration tolerance, negative reaction from others, impulsivity, distractibility, and other problems related to ADHD. There are many ways to calm down. You may already have some that work—if so, keep using them! This exercise will give you more tactics that you can practice and use in your day-to-day activities.

1. List some activities you have a hard time completing, and what gets in the way:

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2. Briefly describe any tactics you have found useful in coping with your symptoms of ADHD (continue to use these as you learn additional methods).

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3. Are there times during the day when it's particularly difficult for you to concentrate, complete activities, get necessary tasks done, or stay calm? If so, when are they? List them in the following spaces.

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4. The following is a list of calming-down strategies. Choose one from the list and practice it for 5 minutes at least three times each day for 1 week. Keep a record of how calm you feel before and after. Use the following rating scale: 1 = very calm; 2 = calm; 3 = no change; 4 = less calm than when you started; 5 = much more upset than when you started. Practice it at different times of the day and note whether it works better at some times than at others.

- a. Deep breathing
- b. Finding a quiet time and place
- c. Using an external cue for focus (for example, wrap yourself in a blanket, hold a stuffed animal or recovery token, gaze at a candle flame, play soft music)

- d. Developing a calming mantra (a word or phrase) to repeat over and over again to yourself
- e. Imagining a peaceful scene full of relaxing details
- f. Taking a walk
- g. Meditating
- h. Changing your focus to something humorous

Remember that repetition is the key—the more you practice any of these, the better they will work. Sometimes other people can help us calm down, but we need to have skills in doing this for ourselves in case those people aren't around.

1. What worked? For items that were not useful, briefly describe what you believe kept them from working for you.

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2. Ask some people you trust what they do to calm themselves. Practice their methods yourself and write the results here.

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3. Write the specific steps you will incorporate into a self-soothing ritual. Which tactics will you use first, second, third, and so on?

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4. What body cues will indicate to you that you are calm and can stop your self-soothing ritual for the time being?

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5. What cues will tell you that you are getting agitated and need to start a ritual again?

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Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.